

A hacker can mean different things depending on how the term is used. Every programmer dreams of being a hacker. Hackers are programming code jockeys that can throw together bits of miraculous pieces of programming seemingly at will. People who modify computer and other pieces of electronic hardware are also sometimes called hackers.

Being a hacker can also be a bad thing. A hacker or hack can sometimes be someone that has no grace or elegance in his work and throws his projects together haphazardly. Thanks to Hollywood, people think that a hacker is a person who gains illicit access to a computer and steals stuff or breaks into military networks and launches missiles for fun and with no conscience.

Hackers aren't always bad people wanting to ruin your lives. There are White-hat hackers and Black-hat hackers. White-hat hackers are ethical hackers who are computers security experts who attempt to gain access to a computer or network to detect vulnerabilities so that they can be patched. White-hat hackers are also called sneakers, red teams or tiger teams. Black-hat hackers gain unauthorised access to a computer or network with malicious intent. They're also called "crackers". For simplicity we've used the popular mass media definition of hackers interchangeably with crackers.

There's a hierarchy in the hacker community too. An advanced cracker writes his own tools and develops his own break-in mechanisms to gain access to computers. Lower down on the hacker food chain are script kiddies. These electronic intruders use freely distributed tools designed by others to engage in computer vandalism, break-ins, or electronic theft.

Who are the hackers?

Looking into hackers' minds, you have to be open to the social aspects behind the way they think. Often portrayed as loners, hackers can be socially involved and fit into what is considered "normal" everyday lives. Regardless of the kind of lifestyle lead, every hacker has a knack for solving puzzles and an attitude to push himself to the limit. Their motivations may be different. Some do it for the money, some for a social or political cause and some just do it for the sheer adrenaline rush.

Hackers usually use social engineering to gain most of their knowledge. "Social Engineering" is the act of getting someone to disclose sensitive information through trust. "Brute force", "exploit" and "dictionary attacks" are usually started through the use of software on the hacker's computer.